EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Did the Prophets See God?

Given Monday 1 July 2024 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 2:10

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon
Essay/Chapters: Essay 2, the end of Chapter 10 (organs used of nature; the prophetic visions and the created glory) and the opening of Chapter 11 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 1 July 2024, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: Where We Are in Essay 2

The essay began with the **unity of Hashem**. Not only that there are not two, but more importantly that there is **no diversity and no change** in HaKadosh Baruch Hu. All His "character traits", as we call them, are included in His oneness. Then came a long discussion of the **Trinity**: its philosophical problems, the verses brought for it, and the different Christian beliefs about it.

Last week we did Chapters 8, 9 and most of 10, where Rav Saadia began on the **anthropomorphic descriptions** of Hashem in the Tanach. His principle: whatever the Torah says that gives Hashem something physical, and whenever we speak of Hashem in human terms, it is metaphor. His proofs:

- Hashem cannot have any substance, since He **created all substance**.
- Verses show Hashem is **above every level** of physical existence.
- As discussed in Essay 1, if Hashem had made the world out of Himself, why would one part of Him choose to become this and another that?

He then set out **ten categories** in which we speak of Hashem. The first was **substance** (a hand, a leg) and the second **quantity** (length, depth, width, being divisible or added to). All of these would limit Him and take away from His completeness and infinite essence. And our tradition agrees: **Onkelos**, a thousand years before Rav Saadia, translated "the hand of Hashem" in the plagues as "a plague from Hashem."

Rav Saadia is the first to say this explicitly, the Rabbi stressed. Those before him did not say it in so many words, but the way they interpreted the verses shows they did not take them literally.

The Organs of Nature

To close the point, Rav Saadia shows how often the Tanach gives **organs to inanimate things**, and how we read these as metaphor without even noticing. "Just like you immediately interpret these things metaphorically, so too when it comes to HaKadosh Baruch Hu." He counts twelve.

Organ	Verse	What it really means
Head	the head of the dust of" ,**וראש עפרות תבל** the world" (Mishlei 8:26)	The beginning
Eye	the locusts "will cover ,**וכסה את עין הארץ** the eye of the land" (Shemot 10:5)	The whole surface. Rashi explains it as covering the sun. A participant suggested "as far as the eye can see." "That's another interpretation of the Rishonim. Very good."
Ear	give ear, O earth"" ,**והאזיני ארץ** (Yeshayahu 1:2)	Bear witness
Face	the quails covered "the face ,**על פני הארץ** of the land" (Bamidbar 11:31, in Beha'alotecha, read a couple of weeks earlier)	Everywhere you looked
Mouth	the earth opened its" ,**ותפתח הארץ את פיה** mouth" and swallowed Korach (Bamidbar 16:32, that week's parasha)	It opened up
Wing	from the wing of the earth"" ,**מכנף הארץ** (Yeshayahu 24:16)	From the edges, as wings are at the edge of the body
Hand	on the hand of the river"" ,**על יד היאר** (Shemot 2:5)	Alongside, since your hands are at your sides
Lip	Moshe placed "on the lip of ,**על שפת היאר** the Nile" (Shemot 2:3)	On the bank, as the lips are at the edge of the face
Heart	in the heart of the sea," as we say" ,**בלב ים** in the Shirah (Shemot 15:8)	The depths, the midst
Navel	on the navel of the land"" ,**על טבור הארץ** (Yechezkel 38:12)	The centre
Belly	from the belly of the" ,**מבטן שאול שועתי** grave I cried" (Yonah 2:3)	From the depths of despair
Womb	the sea "burst forth from ,**בגיחו מרחם יצא** the womb" (Iyov 38:8)	It forced its way out, like a baby from its mother
Thigh	"from the thighs of the earth" ,**מירכתי ארץ**	The far corners of the earth

Just as our **senses** force us to read these twelve metaphorically, because nature plainly has no such organs, so our **intellect** tells us the God we believe in cannot have them either. And if you insist on following the literal text, you will have to say the earth and the water have these twelve organs, "and that's impossible."

So too every similar expression about Hashem: the prophet's plea **הטה אלהי אזנך ושמע, פקח עיניך**, "incline Your ear, open Your eyes"; Hashem saw, Hashem heard, Hashem spoke, Hashem

thought. Each has its interpretation.

"And Hashem smelled"

Rav Saadia singles out one verse as especially harsh: after the Flood, **וירח ה׳ את ריח הניחח**, "Hashem smelled the pleasing aroma" of Noach's offering (Bereishit 8:21). "It's hard for us to accept." It means Hashem **accepted** the offering, and then made the covenant. Rav Saadia's proof is **מריח מים יפרח**, a tree will sprout "from the scent of water" (Iyov 14:9). Plants do not grow from the smell of water. Logic tells us it means from *receiving* water. In the same way, "Hashem smelled" means "Hashem accepted."

The Real Problem: The Prophetic Visions

Now Rav Saadia comes to the final problem in this section. Fine, we interpret "He heard" metaphorically. But the prophets describe **visions** in which Hashem appears, as it were, in very anthropomorphic images:

- The form of a man, seated on a throne.
- The throne like a **sapphire stone**, and above it the likeness of a person (Yechezkel).

> **ראיתי את ה׳ יושב על כסאו וכל צבא השמים עמד עליו מימינו ומשמאלו**, "I saw Hashem sitting on His throne, and all the host of heaven standing by Him, on His right and His left" (Melachim I 22:19).

How do we interpret this?

What we would answer, and what the Rambam answers

The Rabbi asked the class. Based on everything so far, we would say: Hashem is incorporeal, so the throne and the angels on the right and left are the nearest the prophet could come to describing the indescribable. **The prophet never literally saw a throne.** These are metaphors. "That's what the Rambam says."

Rav Saadia: the visions were real, and they were created

"Saadia does not say that. Saadia feels that this is too explicit to be interpreted metaphorically. He understands this to be literal."

But how can it be literal if Hashem has no body? Here Rav Saadia says something fascinating:

Yes, the prophets really saw these images. But **they were created**. The throne, the ministering angels on the right and the left: the Almighty **created** them, to show the prophet that He is there. This is something unique that only the prophets saw, with great grandeur. **This is called the Glory of God**, the **Kavod**.

Daniel describes the same: **ועתיק יומין יתב**, "and the Ancient of Days sat" on a throne (Daniel 7:9). It is a recurring image, and it is called *Kavod Hashem*. This, says Rav Saadia, is what the Sages meant by the word **Shechinah**: a created image, physical and anthropomorphic, displayed to show the prophet that he is in the presence of something immense. Sometimes there is no human figure, and the manifestations differ, but all of them are *Kavod Hashem*.

The proof: Hashem does not speak to the prophets

Rav Saadia's proof is striking. Yechezkel says Hashem told him: **בן אדם עמד על רגליך ואדבר אתך**, "Son of man, stand on your feet and I will speak with you" (Yechezkel 2:1). Rav Saadia says that

cannot be Hashem Himself speaking, because the Torah says **there will never be a prophet like Moshe**, with whom Hashem spoke.

So in all other prophecies it was never Hashem Himself speaking to the prophet. It was a **created image**, of an angel or a throne, which Hashem creates in order to relate and speak to His prophets. Sometimes the text names the angel, and that is a created being. And where it says simply "Hashem spoke" or "Hashem appeared" to anyone other than Moshe, Rav Saadia says **a word is missing**, as Hebrew sometimes omits a word. It means the Glory of Hashem, the angel of Hashem, something of Hashem, not Hashem Himself.

Why this is so surprising

The Rabbi pointed out that the verse does not actually say Hashem never speaks to other prophets. It says:

> There never again arose a prophet in Israel **ולא קם נביא עוד בישראל כמשה אשר ידעו ה׳ פנים אל פנים** like Moshe, whom Hashem knew face to face. (Devarim 34:10)

The usual understanding is that *panim el panim* means Hashem spoke to Moshe **directly and clearly**, with little barrier, compared with the other prophets. The class had learned this in **Derech Hashem** and **Da'at Tevunot** years earlier: the Sages speak of the **aspaklaria**, the "mirror". You can see something through a whole chain of reflections, mirror after mirror. Different prophets saw through different numbers of mirrors. Moshe had only one barrier; the others had many.

"Rav Saadia doesn't understand that. Rav Saadia understands that Hashem Himself never spoke to the prophets. Really quite remarkable."

Two things we learn about Rav Saadia

1. **There is a limit to metaphor.** Rav Saadia is willing to read things metaphorically, but "he doesn't go full on." Organs, hands, legs, standing and sitting can all be interpreted. But when the prophet says **"I saw"**, that is literal, and he has no licence to make it a metaphor. So the prophets did see these things, but what they saw was an image Hashem created, not Hashem.
2. **Prophets never meet Hashem Himself,** only His created glory.

	Rav Saadia	The Rambam
Did the prophets see a throne and angels?	**Yes, literally**	**No**, it is all metaphor
What was it?	A **created** image: the *Kavod Nivra* (created glory), with the *Dibbur Nivra* (created speech) relayed through it	They saw the *middot* of Hashem: mercy on the right, judgment on the left
Does this give Hashem a body?	No, because the images are creations	No, because nothing physical was seen

"I think this is quite a *chiddush*. When I saw this, it took me time to process it, because I wasn't used to this concept. Not the way people are used to understanding it."

A Parallel in the Kabbalah

The Rabbi added a point "to make us aware of, don't worry if we don't fully grasp it." In the Kabbalah too, even when we speak of Hashem, we are **never talking about Hashem Himself**. The highest level beyond the ten Sefirot is the **Or Ein Sof**, the Infinite Light. Even that is not Hashem Himself, who is inconceivable and cannot be grasped in any sense. It is an **emanation**, the highest and most direct one.

"That strikes me as remarkable, that Rav Saadia and the Kabbalists are both saying the same thing in very different terms. They don't know of each other, but they are essentially saying the same thing."

The class discusses Moshe

A participant summarised: Moshe communicated directly with the Almighty, while the other prophets only received messages, as in a dream. Another noted that from that contact Moshe's face shone so that he had to wear a veil, and suggested it changed him physically in ways we lack the tools to understand. The Rabbi agreed that "words are not the tool to describe something which is beyond words."

But he insisted there is still a **large gap** between the Kabbalists and Rav Saadia. According to the Kabbalists and the Ramchal, no human being, not even Moshe Rabbeinu, could communicate directly with HaKadosh Baruch Hu. There is always an *aspaklaria*. Moshe heard Hashem with one barrier; the other prophets with many more. According to Rav Saadia, *panim el panim* means Moshe **did** communicate directly with the divine, while the others saw only something created. "Which is something the brain cannot comprehend."

Richard asked whether Rav Saadia really means something was created, since in the Ramchal prophecy was about visions and awareness of emanations, not created things. Is it more than a dream image? The Rabbi's understanding: not a physical throne actually standing there, but a created **appearance**, which Hashem makes so that the prophet can communicate. And the appearance is very corporeal: the prophet in Daniel truly saw someone seated on a throne. For the Rambam and the Ramchal, by contrast, the prophet saw no such thing. As the class learned in the Ramchal, the essence of prophecy is that the prophet knows he is communicating with the divine, and understanding is imparted to him through images.

Why Is This Discussion Under "Quantity"?

Rav Saadia is working through ten categories: substance, quantity, then "happenings" (Hashem loving or hating), relation (Hashem as King), place, and so on. Why did he put the whole long discussion of organs and prophetic images under the **second** category, quantity, rather than the first, substance?

One of the commentaries on Rav Saadia suggests an interesting answer. There was an early mystical text containing "extremely crude descriptions of HaKadosh Baruch Hu": the length of His legs, the size of His hands, and so on. There is historical evidence it was known in the Gaonic period. So Rav Saadia put the discussion under *quantity*, to dispel any belief that such a book should be read literally. (In this class the Rabbi named the book as **Sefer HaBahir**, which some Rishonim attributed to **Rabbi Nechunya ben HaKanah**, the first-century Tanna who also composed the prayer **Ana BeKoach**. In his recap the following week he referred to it as **Shi'ur Komah**, the text that describes Hashem's "measurements".)

"Be extremely careful learning it," the Rabbi warned. "We cannot accept any of this. If you want to accept it, the only way is metaphorically." A participant mentioned the later teaching of **Rabbi Chaim Vital** linking each part of the body to something above, so that repairing a part of yourself repairs something in heaven. The Rabbi said that is something else entirely, and much later, in the 16th century.

Ana BeKoach

A participant asked about Ana BeKoach, which we say every day in the korbanot of Shacharit and which seems to go to "a different level." The Rabbi said it depends on one's orientation, and it can simply be said as a prayer, but it is meant to be very mystical. The **Ben Ish Chai** writes, and the Rabbi had seen older Iraqi and Indian congregants do this, that everyone stands for it because of its great significance. He remembered **Charlie Morris** standing for it, closing his eyes and going quiet at the end.

Not Everyone Agreed: Rav Moshe Taku

The Rabbi wanted the class to appreciate something. "I don't think any of us seriously believe in a God who has any kind of corporeal description." But this was not accepted by everyone.

Rav Moshe Taku, one of the **Ba'alei HaTosafot**, in France around the 12th century and quoted in halachic works, wrote that Hashem has physical attributes. In fact, "believe it or not, Rav Moshe Taku accuses Rav Saadia of **heresy**." He brings:

בצלמו: physical means something *tzelem*.

- The Midrash that at the Sea they saw Hashem **like a young warrior**, and at Sinai **like an old man**, a grandfather full of mercy.
- The Gemara that in the World to Come Hashem will make a **circle of the righteous**, standing in the middle, and each tzaddik will point to Him.

He read all of these literally.

The Rambam: the opposite extreme

The Rambam made incorporeality one of the **Thirteen Principles of Faith**. The Rabbi noted that it is the **only one of the thirteen with no explicit source** in the Torah or the Talmud. Even Mashiach is clearly in the Gemara. Nowhere does it say Hashem has no body, and yet the Rambam included it and wrote that whoever denies any of the principles is a heretic. "Which means, according to the Rambam, Rav Moshe Taku was a heretic."

The **Ra'avad**, the Rambam's harshest critic, commented that there were people **greater than the Rambam** who held that Hashem has a corporeal aspect. He did not say he held it himself, but he sympathised. The Rabbi also mentioned an academic essay trying to show that even Rashi believed in a corporeal God. "That's not so clear," but especially around France it may have been a more accepted belief.

So, the Rabbi said, this explains why Rav Saadia goes to such lengths, and why the Rambam was so harsh. He doubted that any rabbi or sefer of the last 500 years has put forward such a view.

"I cannot accept that. I think we have to say the Rambam and Rav Saadia are right. I cannot believe in a God who has any kind of physical essence. Rationally Rav Saadia brings good proofs.

As for the verses, I don't think they are conclusive either way. But as Rav Saadia told us, whenever something goes against our logic and rational analysis, we have to interpret it metaphorically."

Chapter 11: Happenings. Does Hashem Love and Hate?

The third category is **accidents**, meaning happenings. Hashem has no happenings and no feelings, because He **created** all happenings and feelings. Where Scripture says Hashem likes, loves, hates or detests something, it means this:

Anything Hashem **commanded** is called "loved" by Him. Not that He actually loves it, but that it is one of His commandments, telling us that we too should pursue it.

So **כי ה׳ אהב משפט**, "Hashem loves justice" (Tehillim 37:28), means it is what He desires and commands.

Whose words are these?

This sparked a sharp debate. One participant argued that even "wanting" or "choosing" limits Hashem, and that human language reduces God. He added that it was David HaMelech, a human, who wrote "Hashem loves justice." David dreamt at night and wrote in the morning. Only Moshe saw God, so these are David's words, not God's.

The Rabbi pushed back. Tehillim is divinely inspired, the words of Scripture, and he offered an analogy:

Think of boys reading the parasha. The words are exactly the same, the same Torah, the same *te'amim*. Yet you can hear which teacher taught each one, from the way he sings and pronounces the words. Every person brings a tiny twist of his own.

The Sages say something similar about **Devarim**. The first four books are Hashem's words dictated. The fifth is Hashem's words "with Moshe's twist." The Rabbi acknowledged that Devarim is clearly a different kind of text, with far more expressive language. The Sages were bothered by this themselves, and answered that it is Moshe describing what he was told.

The prophets likewise all bring the same core messages, which the Rabbi summarised as: **stay away from idols, keep Shabbat, and look after the widow and the orphan**. Each says it in his own way. So when David HaMelech wrote Tehillim, he had visions and wrote them with his own twist, "but those words are still visions from HaKadosh Baruch Hu. That's our belief."

The participant replied that good Torah reading is about **understanding** the words and knowing where to put the emphasis, not about the tune. "If you don't like the analogy, leave the analogy," said the Rabbi. The point stands: the prophets convey Hashem's message with their own human personality, while the Torah is word for word. And when David says "Hashem loves justice," it means this is what His commandments are. Rav Saadia develops this in the rest of the chapter.

Summary

1. **Twelve organs of nature** (the head of the dust, the eye of the land, the mouth of the earth, the lip of the Nile, the heart of the sea…) are read as metaphor without a second thought. Reason requires the same for Hashem.
2. **"Hashem smelled"** means Hashem accepted, as a tree sprouts "from the scent of water."

3. **The prophetic visions** of thrones and angels are, for Rav Saadia, **literal but created**: the *Kavod*, the Shechinah, the created glory and created speech.
4. **Hashem never spoke directly to any prophet but Moshe.** Where the text says "Hashem spoke," a word is missing: the Glory of Hashem.
5. **There is a limit to metaphor.** Organs can be interpreted, but "I saw" cannot. The Rambam, by contrast, reads the visions entirely as metaphor.
6. **The Kabbalah** similarly holds that even the Or Ein Sof is not Hashem Himself, though for the Kabbalists not even Moshe had direct contact.
7. **Why under "quantity"?** Possibly to answer an early mystical text that measured Hashem's limbs.
8. **Not everyone agreed:** Rav Moshe Taku accused Rav Saadia of heresy. The Rambam made incorporeality a principle of faith. The Ra'avad said greater people than the Rambam held otherwise. The Rabbi sides firmly with Rav Saadia and the Rambam.
9. **Chapter 11:** Hashem has no feelings. "Hashem loves justice" means justice is His command.

Coming Up

Next week: the rest of **Chapter 11**, the other categories in which we speak of Hashem, then a couple more chapters on this theme.

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